

about 3,200 words

Run the Bob Wire Home

by Douglass Burley Johnson

My brother Wendell had the empty buttermilk pail in one hand and a jackrabbit's foot in the other, swinging them both, when the birds went over us like a freight train and I turned around and saw the black coming.

That was the fourteenth of April, 1935, a Sunday, in Cimarron County at the far west end of the Oklahoma Panhandle, nine miles north of Boise City. I was twelve. Wendell was seven. It had been the prettiest morning in a month. We had been eating dust since January, dust in the bread and dust in the bedsheets and dust so thick some days that Mama hung wet dishrags over the windows and we ate supper by lamplight at noon, but that Sunday came up blue and clear and warm with no wind at all, and the whole county went out in it like people let out of jail. Folks hung wash. Men stood in the churchyard after preaching with their hats off just to feel the sun. And Mama sent Wendell and me a mile and a half east down the section line with a pail of buttermilk for old Mrs. Pruitt, who had been poorly since her husband died, because a pretty day was too good to waste on sitting.

"If a duster catches you out," Mama said at the door, the way she said it every single time we left the yard, "you find the bob wire and you run it home. Hand over hand. Don't you let go of that wire for anything in this world."

"Yes ma'am," we said, the way we said it every time.

The bob wire was the four-strand barbed wire fence Papa had strung along our section line back in the good years, when the wheat came up to his belt and he bought Mama a Maytag washer with the money. It ran straight east from our corner post to the Pruitt place, a mile and a half of cedar posts and rusty wire, and it was the only straight line between us and anywhere. Papa had not strung any wire since. He had not done a lot of things since. Four years of no rain will do that to a man. He had quit going to church in the fall, after the grasshoppers came through and ate what the wind had left, and he sat on the porch on Sunday mornings now with his hat over his face while Mama took us in the truck. Mama told us not to pester him about it. She said a man has to get his own feet back under him. I had heard her praying for him through the wall at night, low, so he would not hear.

We had delivered the buttermilk and eaten two of Mrs. Pruitt's sugar cookies and started home along the fence when the birds came.

There were thousands of them. Sparrows and larks and blackbirds and doves, every kind of bird in the county, flying south over our heads as low as the fence posts and as fast as they could go, and the noise of their wings was a roar. Jackrabbits came after them, running right past our feet like we were not there. And the air turned cold. One minute it was a warm Sunday and the next it was cold enough to raise the hair on my arms, and I turned around to look north where the birds were coming from.

There was a wall of black across the whole north edge of the world.

It stood up off the ground higher than any thunderhead I had ever seen, flat across the top like a mesa, black at the bottom and brown at the top where the sun still hit it, and it was rolling toward us. I could see it roll. The front of it turned over on itself like a wave coming in, and under it the whole prairie went dark as it came, and it made no sound at all yet. It came on quiet as a cat, and the quiet was the worst part of it.

"Opal," Wendell said. "Opal, it's a black roller."

"Give me the pail," I said.

I took the pail and threw it in the ditch. I grabbed his hand and walked him up to the fence, and I pulled Papa's old leather work gloves out of my coat pocket, the ones Mama made me carry every time I left the yard, and I put the left one on Wendell and the right one on me, so we each had one gloved hand. Then I untied the sash off my Sunday dress and tied one end around his wrist and the other around mine, tight, with a square knot the way Papa taught me to tie off a feed sack.

"You hold the top wire with your glove hand," I said. "Right behind my hand. And you don't let go."

"For anything in this world," Wendell said.

"For anything in this world."

The duster hit us.

It hit like a wall falling over. The wind came first and almost took my feet out from under me, and then the dirt, and then the dark. I put my bare right hand in front of my face, close enough to touch my nose, and I could not see it. Up and down went away. All that was left was the roar, which had come on all at once like a train in a tunnel, and dirt in my eyes and my teeth

and up my nose, and the bob wire in my gloved left hand, cold and thin and alive with the wind humming in it.

I started walking. I slid my hand along the top strand until it bumped a barb, lifted it over, and slid it on to the next one. Barb, lift, slide. Every few yards my hand hit a cedar post and I had to let go of the wire for the space of one breath and find it again on the far side. Behind me I could feel Wendell's sash pulling on my wrist, and every so often I could feel his glove bump the back of mine on the wire. I counted posts. Papa set them a rod apart, sixteen and a half feet. A mile and a half is four hundred and eighty rods. I knew that from school.

At about post forty the wire started to buzz.

It came into my glove before I saw it, a prickling that ran up my arm and into my teeth. Then there was a crack and a little blue spark jumped off the barb in front of my fingers. Then another one. All down the fence, as far as I could see in the dark, which was not far, little blue sparks were jumping off the barbs and running along the wire with a sound like bacon grease. Papa had told us about it. The dry dirt blowing makes electricity, he said, enough to knock a man down if he grabs a pump handle, enough to short out a truck, and men dragged chains behind their cars in the dusters so the cars would not stall. Knowing all that did not help my arm, which hummed from the fingers to the shoulder, and behind me Wendell started crying.

"It bites," he said.

"Hold on anyway."

That was when I saw the first one.

A big blue spark jumped off the wire and lit up the dust for a second, like a flashbulb, and in that second I saw a man standing out in the field to my left, maybe thirty yards off. He was too tall. I want to say that plain. He was taller than our windmill, and our windmill tower was thirty

feet. He stood there in the black wind with the dirt going around him like water going around a post, and he was looking at the fence. I could not see his face. I could see his shape, the long arms, the head too small for the height of him. Then the spark went out and he was gone into the dark.

I stopped so short that Wendell walked into the back of me.

"Opal," he said. "Opal, there's men in the field."

"I know."

"Big men."

"I know. Keep your hand on the wire."

The next spark showed me three of them. They were walking. They walked across the field toward the fence the way men walk across a creek, slow and wide, and the wind did not move them at all. And under the roar of the wind I heard them talking. It came quiet and close, close as somebody talking in my ear, and the voice was kind.

"There's a house this way," it said. "Your papa's this way, Opal. Come off that old wire. It's going the wrong way. You'll smother out there on that wire. Your papa's right here. Let go and come."

And Wendell let go.

The sash went tight on my wrist and yanked me sideways. He had let go of the wire with his glove hand and stepped off toward the voice, and the sash pulled my left hand halfway off the top strand. I grabbed the wire again so hard a barb went through Papa's glove into my palm, and I set my feet and hauled on that sash with my bare right arm like I was hauling a calf out of a ditch, and Wendell came back against me, and I got his hand and put it back on the wire and held it there under mine.

"That ain't Papa," I said into his ear. "That ain't Papa. Papa's at the house. Mama said."

He was crying so hard he was choking on the dirt.

I was crying too. And I was scared like I had never been scared before or since, scared all the way down into my shoes. They were out there in the dark, standing, and I knew how big they were the way you know a bull is in the pen without looking. And all I could think of, of all the things in the world, was Miss Hattie Bowles's Sunday school lesson from that very morning, because that is the way your mind works when you are twelve and about to die. Miss Hattie had told us about the twelve spies Moses sent into Canaan, and how ten of them came back and said the land was full of giants, the sons of Anak, and we were like grasshoppers in our own sight, and so we were in theirs. And how only two of them, Caleb and Joshua, stood up in front of all the people and said, don't you be afraid of them. The Lord is with us. Don't be afraid of them.

We had grasshoppers. Everybody in the Panhandle knew what a grasshopper was worth.

So I said it. I put my mouth right up against the wire and I said it as loud as I could into the roar. "The Lord is with us," I said. "Don't be afraid of them. The Lord is with us. We ain't grasshoppers. We ain't grasshoppers. Jesus, take us home."

The wire lit up.

I do not know any other way to tell it. The little blue sparks on the barbs had been popping here and there along the fence, the way they had been. When I said those words, the blue fire ran out ahead of us along the top strand of the wire, east, toward home, barb after barb, faster than a horse could run, and stayed lit. Somebody might as well have lit a long row of tiny candles down the fence line in the dark, every barb with its own little blue flame on it, as far as I could see, which was suddenly a long way. It made a path. It hummed in my glove, but it did not bite anymore.

And the tall ones did not cross it.

I saw them by that blue light, four or five of them now, walking along beside the fence out in the field, keeping up with us. The blue line ran between us and them. One of them came up close to the wire and bent down, and its head came down near the height of the top strand, and it stopped there like a man stops at the edge of a cliff. It did not put a hand over. They kept talking, all the way, kind and soft and close, your papa's this way, you'll smother, let go. I said Caleb's words back at them every time they talked, over and over, until my throat was raw with dust, and Wendell said them too, behind me, hiccuping between the words.

We ran that bob wire home. I mean we ran. With the blue line to show the way I could see the posts coming, and we went hand over hand as fast as our hands would go, barb, lift, slide, and the barbs tore Papa's gloves to strings and opened up my palm and Wendell's too, and we did not let go. I stopped counting posts. I did not need to count.

The fence ended at our corner post, where the section line met the road.

From the corner post to our front porch was a hundred and ten steps across the bare yard. I had paced it a hundred times playing Red Rover. Across the yard ran no wire at all, only bare dirt and the dark. The blue fire stopped at the last barb on the corner post and went out, and the dark came down black as the inside of a boot, and the roar came back all the way.

And one of them was standing in the yard.

I could not see it now. But I knew it was there, between the corner post and the house, the same way you know somebody is standing behind you in a dark room. And it said, very close, "Stay on the wire, Opal. Stay right there on the wire where it's safe. Don't you come out in the open."

That was the first time any of them had told me to hold on to the wire.

Then, under the roar, I heard Papa.

He was yelling. I had not heard Papa raise his voice in a year. He was out on the front porch, yelling into the duster as loud as a man can yell, and what he was yelling was the Twenty-third Psalm. "The Lord is my shepherd," he was yelling, hoarse, "I shall not want. He maketh me to lie down in green pastures." He yelled it all the way through, and then he started over from the top, and he did not stop.

Mama said never let go of the wire. Mama also said Papa was at the house. I took Wendell's gloved hand off the top strand and held it tight in mine, sash and all. I took my own hand off the wire. And I walked out into the dark yard toward Papa's voice, with my eyes shut tight against the dirt, saying Caleb's words, a hundred and ten steps, right past the place where that tall thing was standing.

It leaned down over us. I knew it by the cold, colder than the duster. And I kept walking and I said it one more time, "The Lord is with us," and the cold went up off of us, up into the black, the way smoke goes up a stovepipe, and it was gone.

At about ninety steps my boot hit the porch step, and Papa's hands came down out of the dark and caught me under the arms.

He hauled both of us up onto the porch and into the house and Mama slammed the door behind us and stuffed a wet towel along the bottom of it. The lamp was lit on the table. Dust hung in the room so thick the lamp looked like a moon in fog. Mama had wet bedsheets nailed over every window. She got down on her knees on the floor and untied the sash from our wrists and took our hands and turned them over in the lamplight, all torn up and black with dirt and blood, and she started washing them in a basin without saying one word.

Papa did not go back out on the porch. He knelt down on the floor beside Mama, in the dust, with his hat in his hands, and I saw his shoulders going. He had dust caked in the wet on his face. When he could talk he said, to nobody, or to Somebody, "I couldn't see the fence. I couldn't see a thing. All I could do was holler."

"You hollered the right thing, Walt," Mama said, and kept washing.

The duster blew all night and through Monday morning. On Tuesday the sun came out over a world gone brown. The dirt had drifted up against the fence so deep that the bottom three wires were buried, and in places only the tops of the cedar posts stuck out. There were no tracks anywhere. The wind had laid the whole county smooth as a sheet. Papa walked the fence line that afternoon all the way to the Pruitt place and back. When he came home he did not say what he had seen out there, and I did not ask him.

The next Sunday Papa drove us to church himself.

I am an old woman now. The government bought up a good part of that blown-out country in the years after and planted it back to grass, and today some of it is the Rita Blanca National Grassland, and the buffalo grass and the sand sage come right up to where our corner post used to be. Wendell grew up and went to work for the Soil Conservation Service and planted shelterbelts of cedar and hackberry across three counties so the dirt would stay put. He passed in 1998. Miss Hattie Bowles lived to be ninety-four.

I still have what is left of Papa's gloves. They are in a cigar box in my dresser drawer, cut to strings across the palms. When my grandchildren ask about the scars on my hands I take out the box, and I tell them about the black roller, and the bob wire, and Caleb, and the blue fire on the barbs.

The one in the yard who wanted me to stay on the wire stays out of the telling. In all these years I have never known what to do with that one. I think about it on the windy nights, when the grass out past the old section line lays down flat in the dark and the fence wire hums. I think about how the same wire that brought us home would have kept us out there forever, if I had listened to the wrong voice telling me to hold on to it. And I think about Papa on the porch, hollering into a dark he could not see through, and me walking toward the sound of it with my hands open.

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